

FREE RESOURCE // THE MASTER OF MUSIC INDUSTRY

The Independent Artist Release Checklist

Everything you need to do before, during, and after dropping a single or album — so nothing falls through the cracks and every dollar gets collected.

// PHASE 1: 8 WEEKS BEFORE RELEASE

MUSIC PREPARATION

- Master your track to streaming standards (-14 LUFS for Spotify, -16 LUFS for Apple Music)

- Export WAV files at 24-bit / 44.1kHz minimum for distribution

- Create stems and alternate mixes for sync licensing potential

Instrumental, a cappella, and TV mix are the most requested

- Register song with your PRO (ASCAP, BMI, or SESAC)

Do this BEFORE releasing — you cannot backdate performance royalty claims

- Register mechanical rights with MLC (Mechanical Licensing Collective)

Free to register at themlc.com — covers all on-demand streams in the US

- Obtain ISRC code for each recording

Your distributor can assign these — never release without them

- Obtain ISWC code for each composition

Register through your PRO when you submit your song

DISTRIBUTION SETUP

- Choose and set up your distributor (DistroKid, TuneCore, AWAL, or direct label deal)

Compare fee structures — DistroKid flat annual fee vs. TuneCore per-release fee

- Upload metadata: song title, artist name, featuring artists, composers, publishers

Incorrect metadata = uncollected royalties. Check every field twice.

- Set your release date minimum 3 weeks out

Spotify editorial pitch requires 7 days; some playlists require 3-4 weeks notice

- Pitch to Spotify for Artists editorial playlists

Log into Spotify for Artists — pitching opens when you upload

- Submit to Apple Music for Artists

- Set up pre-save campaign via Distrokid or Show.co

MARKETING PREP

- Finalize cover art (3000x3000px minimum, RGB, no explicit text unless marked)

- Create 30-second vertical video (Reels/TikTok) for release day

Algorithm favors video content on release day — have it ready

- Write press bio and one-sheet for press/playlist pitching

- Build press list: blogs, playlist curators, local press

SubmitHub, Groover, and Submithub are worth the small investment

- Schedule 3 social posts per week leading up to release

// PHASE 2: 2 WEEKS BEFORE RELEASE

PRESS & PLAYLIST OUTREACH

- Send press release to music blogs and publications

Personalize each pitch — copy/paste pitches get ignored

- Submit to independent playlist curators on SubmitHub

Budget \$20-50 for paid submissions to relevant playlists

- Pitch to podcast hosts in your genre for interview/feature

- Reach out to YouTube channels that cover your genre

- Confirm any PR firm or publicist campaigns are activated

CONTENT CREATION

- Record behind-the-scenes content: studio, making of, lyric breakdown

- Create lyric video or visualizer for YouTube

YouTube is still the #1 music discovery platform globally

- Design social media graphics in all formats (square, story, banner)

- Prepare email newsletter to your list announcing release
- Schedule all social content in advance using Buffer or Later

// PHASE 3: RELEASE DAY

- Post across ALL platforms simultaneously at midnight or 7am local time
- Send newsletter to your email list

Email converts 3-5x better than social for driving streams

- Go Live on Instagram or TikTok to celebrate with fans
 - Share on all relevant subreddits and Facebook groups
 - Text your core fans personally — superfans drive first-day numbers
 - Submit for SoundExchange registration if not already done
- Covers digital radio and streaming royalties for sound recordings
- Screenshot and share any playlist adds in real time

// PHASE 4: POST-RELEASE (ONGOING)

- Monitor streaming analytics weekly for first 30 days
- Spotify for Artists shows save rate, playlist reach, and listener demographics
- Pitch sync licensing to music supervisors
- Film, TV, ads, and video games — start building your sync catalog now
- Register with neighboring rights organizations if touring internationally
- PPL (UK), SOCAN (Canada), APRA AMCOS (Australia)
- Submit for YouTube Content ID to claim revenue on user uploads
- Your distributor may offer this — if not, use AdRev or Audiam
- Analyze performance data and apply learnings to next release
 - Follow up with press contacts who covered the release
 - Begin planning next release with a 90-day gap minimum

YOUR FULL RELEASE INFRASTRUCTURE?

Book a free 20-minute strategy call at themasterofmusic.com